

SKILLS FOR PROFESSIONAL FREELANCERS

Participants Handout

Session 1

Career Planning & Introduction to Freelancing



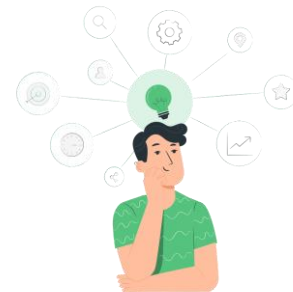
Learning Objectives

- Define career planning and identify the main parts of the Career Diamond.
- Explain how interests, values, personality, skills, and market awareness shape career choices.
- Compare employment, freelancing, and remote or hybrid work using personal and market criteria.
- Use AI-supported prompts to identify a target role and a priority skill gap from job information.
- Build a realistic 30-day SMART career action plan aligned with the selected role.

1 - Career Planning Foundations

Career planning is a decision-making process.

- It helps you choose and pursue a career path intentionally.
- It connects personal traits, interests, values, skills, and market awareness.
- It is reviewed and updated as you gain experience and new information.



Career Planning Helps You To

- Identify what you are good at.
- Translate your skills, talents, values, and interests into possible roles.
- Match your capabilities with existing work opportunities.
- Connect career goals with financial and lifestyle needs.

Three Career Myths to Challenge

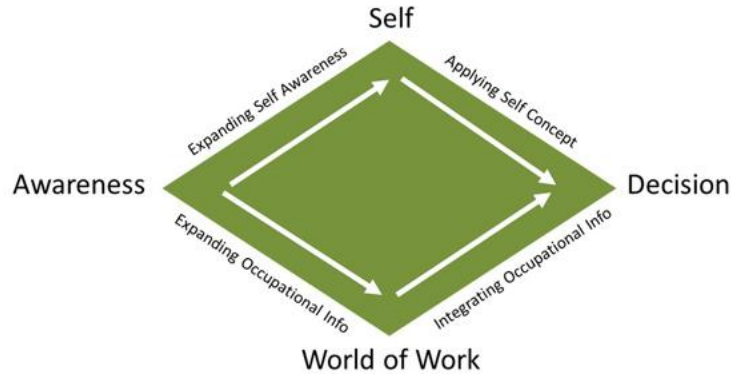
Career Myth	A More Useful Perspective
"The most academically or technically qualified person always gets the job."	Qualifications matter, but employers also consider evidence of performance, communication, attitude, and fit.
"There is only one career that fits me."	Several roles may fit your profile, and your options can change as your interests and skills develop.
"If I am successful, I will automatically be satisfied."	Satisfaction also depends on values, wellbeing, relationships, and the type of work environment you prefer.

Reflect & Write

Which career myth could influence your decisions most, and what perspective will you replace it with?

2 - The Career Diamond

The Career Diamond connects who you are with what the world of work requires.



Diamond Area	What It Includes
Self	Interests, values, personality, skills, strengths, and preferences.
World of Work	Roles, job descriptions, work options, market demand, and emerging trends.
Awareness	Collect evidence about yourself and the opportunities around you.
Decision	Compare the evidence, manage trade-offs, and choose a realistic direction.

Self-assessment is a source of evidence—not a final answer.

Career and aptitude tools, including RIASEC-style assessments, can reveal patterns and possible matches. Use the results as clues, then compare them with real role requirements and your own judgment.

My Self-Awareness Snapshot

Interests	
Values	
Personality clues	
Strongest skills	

Reflect & Write

Which part of your Career Diamond needs the most exploration right now?

3 - Values, Skills & Career Fit

Career Values

Values are deeply held principles that influence what you consider meaningful, fair, and worthwhile. They guide decisions—especially when two attractive options involve different trade-offs.

Examples of Career Values	Questions They Help You Answer
Salary, financial security, job stability	How much predictability and security do I need?
Free time, family and personal life, health	What balance do I want between work and life?
Impact, ambition, competition, growth	What kind of achievement feels meaningful?
Location, work environment, company culture	Where and how do I do my best work?

Skills Are Role-Specific Evidence

A strong career choice matches both your values and the skills required by the role. The presentation uses a Digital Arts Professional as an example:



Reflect & Write

Write the personal evidence you would use when comparing possible roles.

My top three career values:

My strongest three skills:

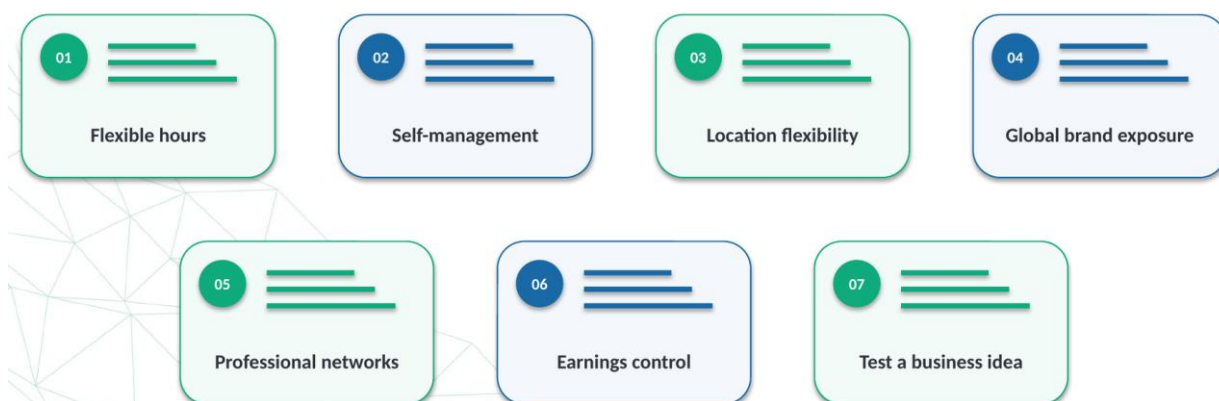
A role or work environment that could match both:

4 - The World of Work

The “World of Work” side of the Career Diamond includes the available work paths, employer or client expectations, market conditions, and the practical realities of each option.

Criteria	Full-Time Employment	Freelancing	Remote / Hybrid Work
Relationship	Employee–employer	Independent provider–client	A location arrangement that can exist in either path
Income pattern	Usually more predictable	Can vary by project and demand	Depends on whether the role is employed or freelance
Autonomy	Usually guided by role and organization	Usually higher; you manage how work is delivered	Varies by team, organization, and contract
Stability	Often higher	Requires a pipeline of clients and careful planning	Remote does not automatically mean stable or flexible
Main responsibility	Perform the role and meet organizational goals	Deliver work and manage marketing, finances, and contracts	Communicate and collaborate effectively across distance

Potential Benefits of Freelancing



Important distinction

Remote work describes where work is done; freelancing describes the working relationship. A remote role may be full-time employment, freelancing, or another contract arrangement.

Reflect & Write

Which work path currently fits your priorities best? Give two reasons based on your values, skills, and practical needs.

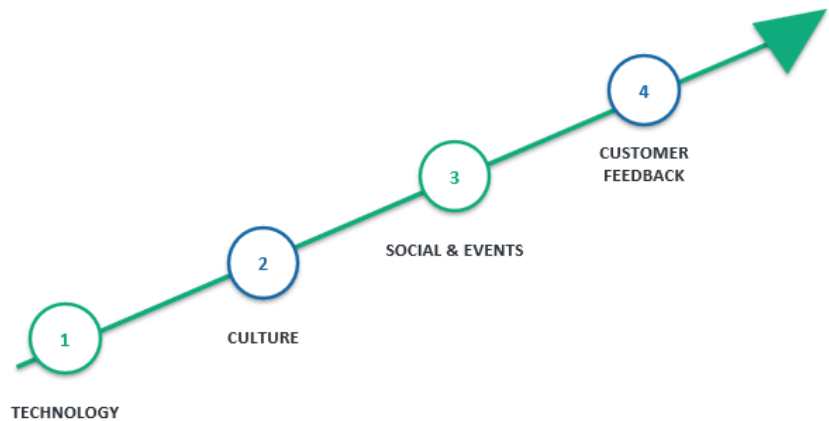
5 - Emerging Trends & the Gig Economy

Emerging trends are patterns, behaviors, or preferences that are gaining influence. They matter when they change what clients need, what employers expect, or how work is delivered.

DEFINITION

Patterns, behaviors, or preferences that are gaining influence in an industry, niche, or audience.

They matter when they change what clients need or how work gets done.



Ask: What is changing—and what new skills does it create demand for?

Where to Look for Change

- **Technology:** new tools, automation, platforms, and delivery methods.
- **Culture:** changing expectations about work, communication, and value.
- **Social events:** events that reshape demand, budgets, or ways of working.
- **Customer feedback:** repeated needs, frustrations, and requests from users or clients.

Gig economy

A labor market in which short-term, project-based, or temporary work is common and organizations engage independent workers for defined assignments.

Reflect & Write

Identify one trend in your field and connect it to a possible skill demand.

Trend I notice:

What it may change for clients or employers:

A skill it may create demand for:

6 - Capabilities the Market Demands

The presentation highlights five capabilities that support employability across changing markets and work arrangements.

Based on the mentioned market trends and freelancer observations, here are some skills you might consider improving to meet the evolving requirements of the labor market:

Adaptability & Continuous Learning

Digital Proficiency

Effective Self-Management & Time Management

Communication & Interpersonal Skills

Business & Entrepreneurship

Capability	Why It Matters	Build It By
Adaptability & Continuous Learning	Specialized work changes quickly.	Use a growth mindset; learn relevant skills; practice deliberately.
Digital Proficiency	Digital tools and online collaboration shape how work is delivered.	Master field-specific tools; strengthen online collaboration; track new technology.
Self-Management & Time Management	Flexible work requires prioritizing and delivering without constant supervision.	Plan deadlines; organize workload; build a focused routine and workspace.
Communication & Interpersonal Skills	Clear communication builds trust and helps retain opportunities.	Present your value; listen actively; network with purpose.
Business & Entrepreneurship	Freelancers operate like small businesses.	Learn marketing and sales; track money; understand contracts and fair terms.

Reflect & Write

Which capability is your first development priority? Write one small action you can complete this week.

7 - Working with Emerging Markets

Emerging markets can create new opportunities, but they also require current information, local understanding, adaptability, and relationship-building.

Practical Move	Why It Matters	What to Do
1. Stay Informed	Fast-moving markets require current evidence.	Follow reliable economic and industry data; compare sources; track changes affecting target roles.
2. Develop Market-Specific Expertise	Local demand, regulations, and industry context improve decisions.	Read industry and government reports; learn local rules; speak with people who know the market.
3. Embrace Flexibility & Agility	Plans must adapt as conditions change.	Test ideas in small steps; review assumptions; build change-management skills.
4. Prioritize Cultural Sensitivity	Trust grows when communication fits local norms.	Learn expectations; adapt communication; ask before assuming.
5. Invest in Relationships	Partners and networks provide context, support, and opportunity.	Attend relevant events; join networks; build trusted local partnerships.

Market awareness is part of career fit.

A role may match your strengths but still be a weak choice if demand is limited, entry requirements are unclear, or the market context does not fit your goals and resources.

Reflect & Write

Choose one market you may want to explore and write your first research steps.

Target market or sector:

One reliable source I will check:

One person, network, or organization I could contact:

8 - Using AI to Support Career Decisions

AI supports thinking—it does not replace your judgment.

Use AI to organize information, compare evidence, and identify possible gaps. Your final output should be a reviewed decision, not a copied AI response.

Step	What to Do
1. Prepare	Choose a preferred role or track. List 3 current skills, 3 career values, and 2 short job descriptions.
2. Ask AI	Check role fit, extract key skills, identify skill gaps, and require evidence from the job descriptions.
3. Decide	Choose one target role, your strongest match, one priority gap, and at least one suggestion you will edit.

Responsible Use Checklist

- Ask the AI to use only the information you provide.
- Require evidence from job descriptions instead of accepting generic claims.
- Check for unsupported assumptions, vague advice, or unrealistic recommendations.
- Avoid sharing sensitive personal information, and edit the final recommendation yourself.

Prompt Example

Based only on the information provided, identify one target role that may fit me, five key skills required for this role, and my top three skill gaps. Explain your answer using evidence from the two job descriptions. Do not assume information I did not provide.

My Decision Card

Target role	
Strongest matching skill	
Priority skill gap	
One AI suggestion I edited	

Reflect & Write

What did you change in the AI output, and why was your edited version more realistic or relevant?

9 - Build a 30-Day SMART Career Plan

A strong career goal uses all five SMART criteria together: it is clear, measurable, realistic, connected to your target role, and attached to a deadline.

S

SPECIFIC

What exactly will you accomplish?

M

MEASURABLE

What evidence will show progress?

A

ACHIEVABLE

Is it realistic with your current time and resources?

R

RELEVANT

How does it support your target role?

T

TIME-BOUND

What is the deadline or review date?

30-Day Plan Template

Week	Learning Task	Practice Task	Measurable Evidence	Checkpoint
Week 1				
Week 2				

Week	Learning Task	Practice Task	Measurable Evidence	Checkpoint
Week 3				
Week 4				

Review before you commit

Is the plan realistic with your available time? Is progress measurable? Does each task support the target role?
What did you edit after reviewing the AI suggestion?

Reflect & Write

What is the first task you will complete, and what evidence will prove that it is done?

Free Tools To Help You Write and Track SMART Goals



https://youtu.be/5Wem6-jgBc0?si=siRzd8eU_bZ_3Byz



https://youtu.be/0Q8aA0Lwuyyc?si=WhGuW0r94LKLju_Z



https://youtu.be/5Wem6-jgBc0?si=siRzd8eU_bZ_3Byz



https://youtu.be/YS19_ETiYyM?si=Fs-xBU5bQJ6555ai

Session Recap & Personal Commitment

Now you can:

- ✓ Define career planning and explain the Career Diamond.
- ✓ Connect strengths, values, and personality with work options.
- ✓ Compare freelancing, employment, and remote or hybrid arrangements.
- ✓ Use AI to scan role fit and identify a priority skill gap.
- ✓ Build a 30-day SMART career action plan.



My Career Commitment

Target role	
Priority skill gap	
First action within 48 hours	
Hours I will invest each week	
Evidence I will produce	
Review date	
Person who can support or hold me accountable	

Keep the plan active.

Review this handout after 30 days. Keep what worked, change what did not, and update your Career Diamond with the new evidence you gained.